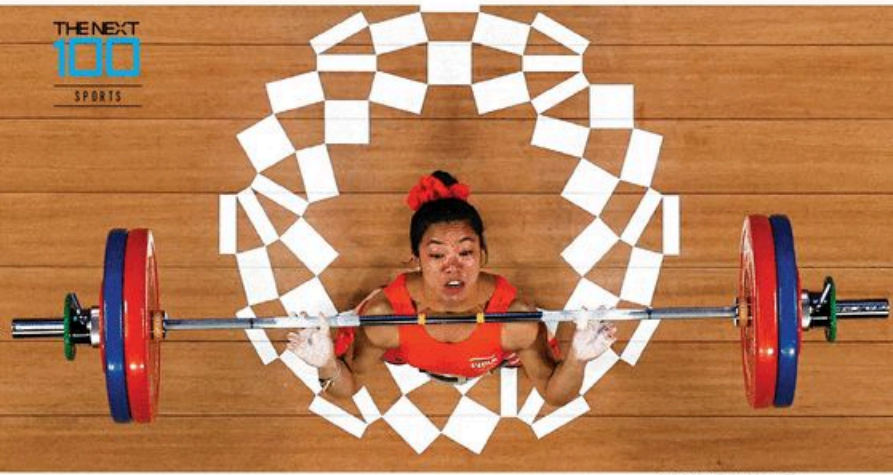


CHRIS GRAYTHEN/POOL/AFP

SAIKHOM MIRABAI CHANU, 27

Weightlifter, Nongpok Kakching, Manipur

Iron Willed

When Saikhom Mirabai Chanu ended up on the podium at the Tokyo Olympics, she not only opened India's medal account but also became the first Indian weightlifter to win a silver at the games. With that glorious entry to the record book, the diminutive girl from Manipur proved that she doesn't give up. Five years ago, at the Rio Olympics, she had failed to register a single legal lift in the clean and jerk. While her win at Tokyo exorcised the ghost of Rio, her sights are set still further—aiming for a gold at the 2024 Paris Olympics. It's not an impossible goal for someone whose commitment to her sport remains non-negotiable and is ready to make many sacrifices. After the Rio debacle, she gave up using her mobile phone, and even now, rarely uses it. However, there are certain relationships in life that this Khel Ratna winner doesn't like to ignore or forget. When she returned from Tokyo, Chanu went looking for, and found, the truck drivers who in her early days as a budding athlete gave her free rides from her home in Nongpok Kakching village to the training centre at the Khuman Lampak sports complex in Imphal, majorly easing the financial cost of her training. ■

–Kaushik Deka

"What strikes me most about Mirabai is her mental strength. To retain one's self-belief even when faced with the most adverse situation is extremely difficult. That's why she is an inspiration to millions"

N. BIREN SINGH
Chief Minister, Manipur

OFF THE CLOCK Mirabai loves doing paper craft and cooking in her free time, and enjoys dancing to to the songs of Neha Kakkar. Her guilty pleasure on cheat days is pizza